

Stephen Ta

Professor Stillman

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Octavia E. Butler's *Dawn* under the Eyes of Biopower

"You people should be thanking Christ that I am who and what I am, because you need me. You need me to save you. You do. I am the only one who possibly can" ("The Only Man in the Sky"). Homelander, the main antagonist of the series *The Boys*, is not simply boasting. He is revealing the logic of domination hidden inside the idea of rescue: that a savior's power grows because others depend on being saved. This is the same idea that stands at the center of Octavia E. Butler's *Dawn*. The connection is not that Homelander and the Oankali are the same kind of beings. It is that both stories show how rescue can become domination when the rescued people are not allowed to refuse the terms of being saved. The end of the world in Butler's novel is not a sudden disaster but the result of human habits carried to their most destructive limit. Butler imagines a future where humanity survives only after proving that intelligence was not enough to save it from hierarchy, violence, and ecological ruin.

The novel follows Lilith Iyapo, a human survivor who wakes aboard the ship of the Oankali, an alien species that has rescued the remaining humans after nuclear war and environmental devastation have made Earth nearly unlivable (Butler). At first, the Oankali seem like the kind of saviors humanity would hope for. They have preserved human life, healed Earth, and offered humanity a future. Yet Butler quickly complicates this rescue by revealing that the Oankali do not intend to restore humanity as it was. Instead, they plan to merge genetically with humans in the name of "improving the species" (Butler). Through this first-contact plot, Butler

turns science fiction into an ethical and ecological problem about survival, power, and the cost of being saved by a stronger force.

The central tension of *Dawn* comes from the Oankali's diagnosis of humanity. In particular, they believe human beings are fatally flawed because they combine intelligence with hierarchy (Butler). This judgment seems persuasive because human civilization has already ended in war, ecological collapse, and death. However, Butler does not allow readers to accept the Oankali's view too easily. The Oankali claim to cure human destructiveness, but they also control human bodies, reproduction, memory, and choice (Butler). Their rescue repeats the same problem it claims to solve, which is domination. In *Dawn*, Butler presents humanity's "fatal" combination of intelligence and hierarchy as a root of nuclear violence, environmental collapse, and interpersonal domination. Still, the novel does not simply agree with the Oankali that humans must be biologically corrected. When reviewed through Michel Foucault's idea of biopower, Andrew Plisner's ecocritical analysis of *Dawn*, and the recurring savior problem in *The Boys*, Butler's novel shows that the Oankali's rescue is dangerous because it controls life itself, while Lilith's resistance reveals the importance of consent inside any future that claims to be healing (Plisner).

Butler first frames humanity's crisis through the Oankali's claim that intelligence becomes dangerous when it serves hierarchy instead of restraining it. The Oankali explain to Lilith that human beings are not dangerous simply because they are intelligent. The danger comes from intelligence combined with hierarchy. As Jdahya tells Lilith, "You are hierarchical. That's the older and more entrenched characteristic," and when intelligence served this older trait instead of guiding it, humanity ignored a danger that was "like ignoring cancer" (Butler 27). The comparison to cancer matters because it makes hierarchy seem internal, spreading, and

potentially fatal. Cancer is not an outside enemy. It is the body turning against itself. In the same way, the Oankali describe human hierarchy as a destructive pattern built into humanity's social and biological life.

Yet, Butler makes this diagnosis uncomfortable because the Oankali are not neutral observers. They are the ones explaining human nature to Lilith while keeping her captive. Early in the novel, Lilith realizes, "She did not own herself any longer. Even her flesh could be cut and stitched without her consent or knowledge" (Butler 2). This line is important because it shows that the Oankali's rescue already begins with control over her body. They name hierarchy as humanity's fatal flaw, but they also hold almost total power over the human survivors. This means their judgment must be read critically. They may correctly identify a destructive pattern in human history, but their authority to define and "repair" humanity is itself hierarchical.

Foucault's idea of biopower helps explain why the Oankali's control is more complicated than normal violence. In *The History of Sexuality: Volume 1*, Foucault describes biopower as a modern form of power that manages life, bodies, reproduction, health, and populations rather than only threatening death (Foucault). This idea fits *Dawn* because the Oankali do not only imprison humans or force them to obey. They also decide how human bodies will be changed, how reproduction will work, and what kind of species humanity will become. *The Boys* gives a more public and commercial version of the same danger. In "The Name of the Game," A-Train kills Robin, but the world of the show still protects the public image of superheroes as necessary protectors ("The Name of the Game"). Their power is not only political. It is biological, social, and public. They rule humans by managing the conditions of human life itself.

At the same time, *Dawn* turns environmental collapse into the visible consequence of hierarchy. Earth in the novel is not merely a ruined setting. It is evidence. The planet has been

devastated because human intelligence served competition, domination, and militarized power rather than mutual survival. The nuclear destruction that precedes the novel shows that human hierarchy does not stay inside governments, armies, or social institutions. It expands outward until it damages the conditions of life itself. Butler's apocalypse is ecological, but not in a narrow sense. The ruined Earth reflects a deeper failure in relation. Humans failed to relate ethically to one another, and that failure became an environmental catastrophe.

Andrew Plisner's article "Arboreal Dialogics: An Ecocritical Exploration of Octavia Butler's *Dawn*" is useful because it treats ecology in Butler's novel as more than a simple concern for nature. Plisner's ecocritical reading connects ecology with African Diasporic memory, gender, culture, society, hegemony, bodily invasion, and colonial subjectivity (Plisner). This approach helps show that *Dawn* does not separate environmental issues from questions of power and identity (Plisner). In the novel, bodies, communities, environments, and histories are linked. The devastated Earth is not only a damaged landscape. It is the material result of broken relationships. Human beings dominate one another, and then they reproduce that domination against the planet.

Lilith's role as mediator complicates the Oankali's solution because she must help preserve human survival while also participating in a system that denies human consent. Lilith is chosen by the Oankali to awaken and train other humans (Butler). This role gives her unusual knowledge and limited authority, but that authority is granted by her captors. She is neither fully free nor fully powerless. She understands the Oankali better than the other humans do, and this understanding allows her to help the survivors adapt. It also isolates her from them. To the other humans, Lilith's cooperation makes her appear suspicious and even traitorous. Butler uses this painful position to show the emotional cost of survival under unequal power.

In addition, Lilith's characterization prevents the novel from becoming a simple conflict between humans and aliens. She is not merely a victim, because she makes decisions, protects others, and resists when she can (Butler). She is not simply a collaborator, because her cooperation is shaped by captivity and limited choice. She is not a heroic savior because she cannot fully control the consequences of her actions. Instead, Lilith becomes the figure through whom Butler explores compromised agency. Her mediation reveals how difficult ethical action becomes inside a coercive system. She wants humans to survive, but the only available path to survival requires participation in the Oankali plan.

Plisner's attention to corporeal invasion and colonial subjectivity helps illuminate Lilith's conflict. The Oankali do not only rescue human beings from outside. They enter human bodies, reproduction, and futures (Butler). Their relationship to humans is ecological because it involves biological interdependence, but it is also colonial because it involves control over another group's destiny (Plisner). Lilith's body and identity become sites of conflict between survival and autonomy. The Oankali's genetic trade is presented as healing, but for Lilith and the other humans, it also feels like invasion. Butler refuses to separate ecological adaptation from the politics of consent. A future may be biologically possible and still ethically troubling.

Although the Oankali describe their genetic trade as a rescue, Butler shows that rescue becomes dangerous when one group has the power to decide what another group's future should be. The Oankali claim they are saving humans from their "fatal" combination of intelligence and hierarchy, but they also control human bodies, reproduction, and survival. Jdahya tells Lilith that the Oankali "trade the essence" of themselves, meaning their genetic material, and later admits that human young will become "more like us" while Oankali young become more like humans (Butler 28-29). This is where biopower becomes central to the argument: the Oankali do not only

rule humans through force. They rule by managing life itself. Their good intentions make them blind to the harm they cause because they see consent as less important than biological improvement.

The clearest moment comes when Jdahya explains that “the ooloi will make changes in your reproductive cells before conception and they’ll control conception” (Butler 29). Lilith’s response is immediate: “No. I don’t care what you do with what you’ve already learned . . . but leave us out of it. Just let us go” (Butler 29). This exchange shows why the Oankali’s rescue cannot be treated as pure kindness. The word “trade” makes the exchange sound fair, but Lilith’s refusal shows that the humans are not equal partners. This is the same pattern *The Boys* exposes through Homelander and Vought. In that series, superheroes are sold to the public as protection, but the people harmed by them are treated as acceptable damage to preserve the system (“The Name of the Game”). Like Homelander, who believes people should thank him because they “need” him, the Oankali turn dependence into justification (“The Only Man in the Sky”). Butler therefore suggests that unequal power can make even a savior reproduce domination while believing it is acting for the greater good.

This is where Butler becomes most critical of the Oankali. Their diagnosis may be accurate, but their cure is forceful. They condemn hierarchy while placing themselves above humans as judges, healers, and designers of the future. Foucault’s theory makes this contradiction clearer. If biopower works by managing bodies, reproduction, and populations, then the Oankali’s forced transformation of humanity cannot be pure rescue (Foucault). It is another form of imposed order. The Oankali may not resemble human conquerors in a simple way, but they still deny humans full self-determination. Their version of survival comes at the cost of consent.

Butler's most important contribution is that she neither fully condemns nor fully redeems humanity. Instead, she presents human nature as a paradox of violence and ethical possibility. The Oankali see human beings as biologically doomed by hierarchy, and the history of the novel seems to support them (Butler). Human beings have destroyed Earth through nuclear war, proving that intelligence can become catastrophic when joined to domination. The awakened humans also show fear, suspicion, sexism, and violence. Their reactions often seem to confirm the Oankali's judgment.

However, Butler complicates this judgment through Lilith. Lilith is intelligent, grieving, angry, protective, and capable of empathy. She does not represent a humanity free from hierarchy, but she does reveal that human beings are more than their worst tendencies. Even the fear and hostility of the other humans must be understood in context. They are traumatized survivors who wake in captivity, surrounded by beings they do not understand, and denied control over their own futures. Butler does not excuse their violence, but she shows that it emerges from fear, powerlessness, and social conditioning as well as from biology.

This distinction matters because it challenges the Oankali's biological determinism. If the human problem is purely genetic, then the Oankali's solution may seem necessary. But if the problem is also about power over bodies and populations, as Foucault's idea of biopower suggests, then survival cannot be separated from consent (Foucault). Lilith's uneasy ethical relation to both humans and Oankali suggests that resistance to hierarchy is still possible, even if it is fragile (Butler). She cannot escape the system entirely, but she continues to care, question, and protect. Her conflicted role becomes the novel's evidence that human beings may still possess a capacity for ethical relation.

In conclusion, *Dawn* matters because Butler uses alien encounter to make familiar human problems strange. Through the Oankali, she forces readers to confront the possibility that human hierarchy has made intelligence dangerous. Through the devastated Earth, she shows that social violence can become ecological collapse. Through Lilith, she reveals the emotional and ethical burden of survival under coercive power. Through the Oankali's genetic trade, she questions whether rescue can truly be benevolent when it removes consent (Butler). The novel's power comes from refusing easy answers. The Oankali may be right that human hierarchy is deadly, but their cure repeats domination in another form.

The *Boys* comparison returns here because it makes Butler's warning easier to see. Homelander is frightening because he believes his power makes him necessary, and Vought is frightening because it turns that necessity into a system that protects itself. The Oankali are less openly cruel, but their logic is still similar. A savior becomes dangerous when he, or they, begins to believe that dependence is the same as consent. *Dawn* shows that moral awakening means little when it exists inside systems of fear, control, and unequal power. The novel suggests that humanity's future depends not only on intelligence or survival, but on whether beings can build relationships that do not turn difference into hierarchy. In that sense, Butler's *Dawn* remains relevant because survival under biopower may preserve life while still taking away the freedom that makes life human.

Works Cited

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